

Weekly Reading Reflections #4: Sergio Monterroso

Assessing Heritage Museums (Longstreet Museum)

What did you choose? Why?

The Longstreet Society's Museum is based in Gainesville, GA in the town that Confederate General James Longstreet chose to settle down in after the war because of connections he had in the area with his family. Longstreet is the principal character of my project and has a checkered history narrative because of his political actions after the war when he joined the Republican Party during Reconstruction. His character has faced many impurities because of false narratives based on hearsay by other leaders of the Confederacy, despite his record being better than those who spread rumors about him.

What interested you?

The Longstreet Museum is facing an uphill battle of pushing "truth" against popularity. According to Reeve, the best museum type for this environment would assumably be the temple-style of museum — one which features teaching from the "top-down" of a controlled narrative as opposed to the laboratory-style which lays the information out to the spectator who makes their own judgments on the narrative they subscribe to. Despite this, the Longstreet Museum uses a laboratory-style of learning instead of education, yet they still achieve their goals of pushing this rock up the metaphorical hill.

I walked in with the assumption that the only historically significant Confederate leaders were Lee, Jackson, and Davis. There are countless statues, memorials, and tributes to these three leaders in the South, so I had not thought much of other leaders in the Confederate Army. For me to understand the Longstreet narrative that the museum wanted to push on me, they would have to "break" this initial narrative that I held. This is a feat that the laboratory-style of teaching would find difficult because there isn't a controlled narrative that the Longstreet Museum is pushing to directly counter my previous narrative. Instead, the museum requires me to do that on my own — and yet, I did.

What do you wish you could change? Achieving goals? Understanding Exhibits?

For the most part, the Museum is achieving its goals of changing the narrative that has haunted General Longstreet during the later part of his life, and after it. There are little changes that can be made besides reorganization of some "exhibits" to better focus on Longstreet as opposed to the Confederate Army itself. For example, there is one room near the front entrance of the museum that is used for confederate memorabilia like uniforms, army figurines, and knick-knacks that don't serve a purpose to the museum's goal. Aside from that, the rest of the museum functions well at maintaining a repository of Longstreet's life through primary source documents.

Surprisingly, visitors do understand the narrative that the Longstreet Museum is trying to espouse. In my visit, there were times where a volunteer had to explain an exhibit to the spectator but the conversations between visitors that I overheard during my studies at their library were impressive. Many of them were discussing the exhibits and surprised at the life of the most strategic Confederate General that they had never heard of. Many of

them even questioned why the authorized Confederate heritage narrative neglected to include Longstreet alongside names like Lee or Jackson, but this would require a more advanced understanding of Longstreet and his politics for spectators to know. This part of the learning experience is difficult to show through museum exhibits. How can you show politics? How can you show the “feelings” of Southerners against their once-praised General who now espoused Reconstructionist views? The museum does its best by pulling from newspapers to show the hate that Longstreet suffered because of his politics, but newspapers are newspapers and can’t show everything.

More research is needed on this topic, which my project will hopefully cover in better detail.